

A few email templates on how to ask for things via email

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1 Notes about templates below:

These were originally intended for PhD students applying for postdocs, but they've been modified and expanded for master's students applying to PhD programs.

This includes:

- How to ask for letters of recommendation.
- How to reach out for a meeting with someone you haven't met ("cold email").
- What to include when someone agrees to help.

2 Before You Ask

If you're a master's student applying to PhD programs, think of:

- **Who to ask:** Ideally, your letter writers should know your academic or research work. This can be a research advisor, a course instructor (if it was a project-intensive course), or someone you worked with on a significant academic experience.
- **How many:** You'll typically need 3 strong letters of recommendation.
- **If unsure: It's okay to ask:** "Do you feel comfortable writing me a strong letter of recommendation for PhD applications?" That wording gives them a polite exit if they don't know you well.
- **When to ask:** Ask at least 4-6 weeks in advance, if possible. Sooner is always better.
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- **Cold emailing?** If you want to do research with someone (before or after applying), you can and should cold email them—but personalize it and do your homework first.

3 What to Send a Recommender (Once They Say Yes)

When someone agrees to write you a letter: Send them the following in a single email:

- Your CV
- Your transcript (unofficial is fine)
- A draft of your personal or research statement
- A list of schools/programs you're applying to with due dates
- A short list of talking points or highlights you'd like them to mention
- (Optional) A gentle reminder of how they know you if it's been a while
- If the recommender is extremely busy or doesn't know you well, it's not unusual to offer a draft letter they can edit. This is especially true for course instructors or collaborators on large projects.

4 Example of How I requested letters of recommendation:

Email Subject Header: *Your Name:* Request for PhD Letters of Recommendation Hello ****insert name****, I hope this email finds you well.

This Fall, I will be applying to several PhD programs and I would like to formally ask you if you feel comfortable writing a strong letter of recommendation on my behalf?

Working with you through *insert how you know them* (class, project, research, etc.) has been very important to my development as a student and aspiring scientist. I believe you could honestly and effectively speak to my preparation for graduate-level research.

I've attached my CV and a general draft of my personal statement. I've also included a list of the programs I'm applying to, along with deadlines and submission instructions. If you need anything else from me to help, please let me know.

Thank you so much for your time and support!

5 Example of How I Requested a Letter of Support from a Potential PhD Advisor:

Email Subject Header: Your Name: Letter of Support for ****Program Name****

(This is assuming you've ALREADY met with them to discuss post-doc applications)

Hello Dr. ****insert name****,

Thank you so much for meeting with me to discuss your research group. I intend to submit an application to the ****program name**** and list ****insert institution**** as my intended school. Would you be willing to write a short letter of support on my behalf before the deadline on ****insert date****?

If you're able to help, I've attached my draft research statement and pasted the letter instructions below. Let me know if you need anything else from me to make this easier. In most cases, you would email the letter to me directly so I can upload it with my application.

Thanks again for your time and consideration!

6 Example of Cold Emails for setting up meetings before application due dates:

Email Subject Header: Your Name: Applying to ****insert program name**** Fellowship

Hello Dr. ****insert name****, I hope this email finds you well.

My name is ****insert name****, I am a Master's student at ****insert institutional program**** and I work in Dr. ****insert advisor name****'s research group. This Fall, I'm applying to PhD programs and after reading several recent papers from your research group, I believe our interests are strongly aligned. To briefly summarize, I specialize ****insert 1-2 sentences describing your specialty****. ****insert a publication you have and in same sentence, describe the main result****.

I am particularly interested in the ****insert research group name**** collaboration that you lead and I'd like to learn more about the group. Over the last year or so I've developed a strong interest in ****insert specific interest that your proposal will be about****. Many of the members of the ****insert research group name**** collaboration, such as ****insert member name**** and ****insert another member name****, have all led studies that I learned a great deal

from, and I would love to be a part of your research group.

I would like the opportunity to discuss doing a postdoctoral fellowship in your research group as a Fellow. I anticipate graduating later this coming Spring with the intention to begin a postdoctoral position in Fall, 202X. If you would like to discuss this further, I have attached my CV for the context of my expertise, and you can contact me at ****insert email address****.

Thank you so much for your time and I hope to hear from you soon!

7 If You Don't Hear Back at all

Professors are often swamped and emails get lost. It's okay to follow up once after a week or so. Keep it polite and simple:

- "Just following up on my earlier message in case it got buried. I'd still love the chance to connect if you're available!"

If they don't respond after that, move on—don't take it personally.

If they decline to write you a letter: thank them and find someone else. You want letters from people who are enthusiastic and can strongly advocate for you.

Good luck! Be polite, be specific, and make it easy for others to help you.